

Ptychozoon kuhli

Kuhl's flying gecko



Length 7–8 in
(18–20 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Arboreal
Status Not evaluated

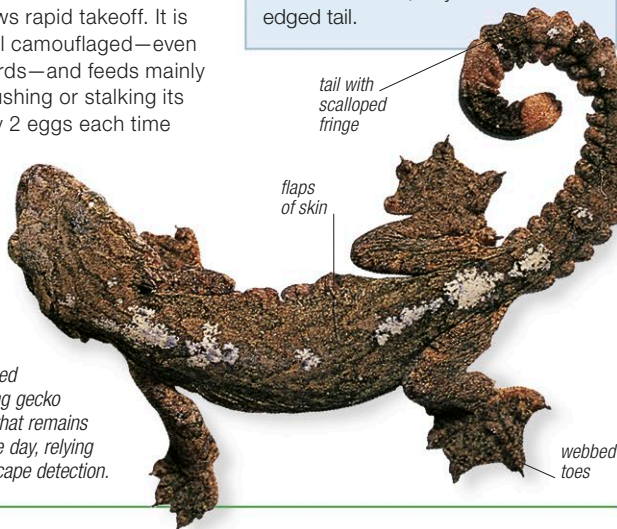
Location S.E. Asia



This tropical forest gecko is one of several lizards that escape danger by jumping from trees and gliding through the air. When not airborne, it often rests head down on tree trunks—a posture that allows rapid takeoff. It is exceptionally well camouflaged—even by gecko standards—and feeds mainly on insects, ambushing or stalking its prey. Females lay 2 eggs each time they breed.

COLORED FOR CAMOUFLAGE

Mainly brown or grayish brown, with indistinct, dark, mottled markings, Kuhl's flying gecko is a nocturnal lizard that remains motionless during the day, relying on camouflage to escape detection.



FLYING FEET



Unlike the flying lizard (see p.411), Kuhl's flying gecko glides mainly with its strongly webbed feet. Its fall through the air is also controlled by flaps of skin along its flanks, and its flattened, frilly-edged tail.

Rhacodactylus leachianus

New Caledonian gecko



Length 12–14 in
(30–35 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Arboreal
Status Least concern

Location New Caledonia

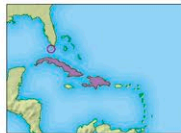


This is an extremely large gecko that can reach as much as 16 in (40 cm) in length, although it is usually smaller. Mottled brown, with a large head and eyes, and a small, thin tail, it lives on tall



Sphaerodactylus elegans

Ashy gecko



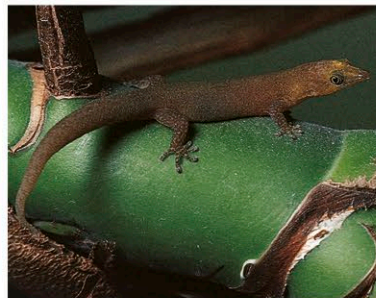
Length 2¼–3 in
(7–7.5 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Not evaluated

Location Caribbean



This tiny gecko is brown, with very fine, speckled white markings and a pointed snout. A lively but short-lived animal, it forages constantly among leaf litter and debris in woods and near houses,

catching small insects with a quick dart. Although mainly diurnal, it may also be active at night, often near street lights. Females lay one egg at a time in communal nests—behind bark, among dead leaves, or in crevices.



Stenodactylus sthenodactylus

Elegant sand gecko



Length 3½–4¼ in
(9–10.5 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Not evaluated

Location N. and E. Africa,
W. Asia



This dainty-looking lizard has long limbs, a thin tail, and a slender, beige or sand-colored body, with darker bands and small, pale spots on its back. Its eyes are large, and it has a slightly upturned snout. A skillful digger, the elegant sand gecko lives in holes in the ground or under stones, and buries its eggs in the sand. It becomes active at dusk, when it hunts for termites, ants, small moths, and small beetles and their larvae, walking with a stiff-legged gait to gain a better view of the surroundings. If threatened, usually by birds, this gecko may arch its back to appear larger.



Tarentola mauritanica

Moorish gecko

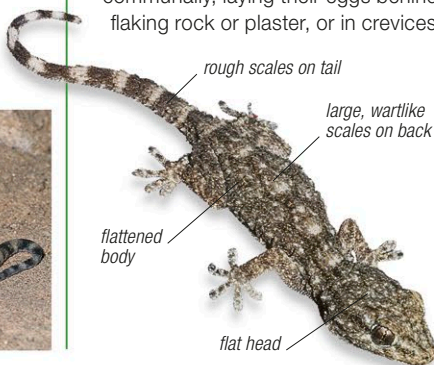


Length 4–6½ in
(10–16 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Least concern

Location S. Europe,
W. Asia, N. Africa



The stocky, grayish or brown Moorish gecko often occurs in high densities in rocky scrub, drystone walls, and buildings; it occupies vertical surfaces, and seldom moves far from a crack into which it can retreat. Active mainly at night, in cooler weather it may also be active during the day, and it hibernates in winter. This gecko frequently waits in likely hunting areas, often near lights, and pounces on insects, such as moths, that come near. Females may nest communally, laying their eggs behind flaking rock or plaster, or in crevices.



Saltuarius cornutus

Northern leaf-tailed gecko



Length 6–8½ in
(15–21 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Arboreal
Status Least concern

Location E. Australia



Geckos are generally noted for their camouflage, but this eastern Australian species excels at this form of defense. It has cryptic, gray mottled coloration, a flattened body that is shaped to eliminate shadows, and a remarkably

leaflike tail, which can be shed if the animal is attacked (males have a paired bulge at the base of their tail). This gecko is practically invisible when resting on tree trunks and among foliage in its tropical forest habitat, and only gives itself away when it moves. Males are territorial, and females lay 2 eggs at a time in cracks behind bark. Northern leaf-tailed geckos feed mainly at night, actively foraging for insects, which make up most of their diet.

